

Northgate University

Information Classification Policy

An ISO/IEC 27001:2013 aligned document · Internal Use Only

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Classification	Internal Use Only
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Policy Owner	Chief Information Security Officer
Approved By	Information Governance Board
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Aligned Standard	ISO/IEC 27001:2013 — Annex A.8.2

1. Purpose

This policy establishes the framework by which Northgate University ("the University") classifies its information according to sensitivity and the potential impact of unauthorised disclosure, modification, or loss. Consistent classification enables the University to apply proportionate security controls, meet its legal and regulatory obligations, and protect the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of information.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all information created, received, processed, stored, or transmitted by the University in any format — electronic, physical, or verbal. It applies to all staff, students, contractors, and third parties who access University information or systems, including information held on University-managed systems and on personal or third-party devices used to conduct University business.

3. Information Classification Scheme

All University information is assigned one of the four classification levels below. Where information is unclassified or unlabelled, it is treated as Internal Use Only by default. Classification is determined by the most sensitive element of information held within a document or dataset.

Classification	Description	Typical Examples	Impact if Compromised
Public	Approved for unrestricted release to the public; disclosure causes no adverse impact.	Published research, prospectuses, public website content, press releases.	None
Internal Use Only	For general access by staff and students; not for public	Internal announcements, intranet pages, non-	Minor

Classification	Description	Typical Examples	Impact if Compromised
	release. Default classification for unlabelled information.	sensitive operational documents.	
Restricted	Access limited to specific roles, teams, or departments for operational reasons.	Operational procedures, internal management reports, supplier contracts, non-personal financial records.	Moderate — operational disruption or reputational harm.
Confidential	Highly sensitive; access restricted to named, authorised individuals on a need-to-know basis.	Personal data of staff and students, sensitive research data, authentication credentials, security configurations, legal and disciplinary records.	Severe — legal or regulatory penalty, serious reputational damage, or harm to individuals.

4. Information Handling Requirements

Handling controls must be applied in proportion to classification. The following minimum requirements apply:

- **Access control.** Information must only be accessible to those authorised for its classification level. Restricted and Confidential information must be protected by role-based access controls that are reviewed at least annually.
- **Storage.** Restricted and Confidential information must be stored on University-approved systems. Confidential information must be encrypted at rest. Storage on personal devices is permitted only where the Remote Working Policy allows it and device encryption is enabled.
- **Transmission.** Confidential information must be encrypted in transit (for example, TLS, encrypted email, or approved secure file transfer) and must not be sent to personal email accounts or unapproved third-party services.
- **Sharing with third parties.** Sharing Restricted or Confidential information externally requires Information Asset Owner approval and, for personal data, a documented lawful basis and appropriate contractual safeguards.
- **Physical handling.** Printed Confidential material must not be left unattended and must be stored securely when not in use.
- **Disposal.** Information must be disposed of securely in line with its classification — secure deletion for electronic media and cross-cut shredding or approved destruction for physical media (ISO/IEC 27001:2013 A.8.3.2).

5. Labelling of Information

Information classified as Restricted or Confidential must be clearly labelled with its classification. Electronic documents should display the classification in the header, footer, or document metadata; physical documents should be marked on the cover or first page. Information that is not labelled is treated as Internal Use Only (ISO/IEC 27001:2013 A.8.2.2).

6. Roles and Responsibilities

- **Information Asset Owners (IAOs).** Assign and review the classification of information assets within their area of responsibility and ensure appropriate handling controls are applied.
- **Chief Information Security Officer (CISO).** Owns and maintains this policy, defines the classification scheme, and oversees compliance.
- **Data Protection Officer (DPO).** Advises on the classification and handling of personal data and on regulatory obligations.
- **All staff, students, contractors, and third parties.** Handle information in accordance with its classification and report any suspected misclassification, loss, or unauthorised disclosure.
- **Information Governance Board.** Approves this policy, oversees its implementation, and adjudicates classification disputes.

7. Compliance and Enforcement

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. Failure to comply may result in disciplinary action in accordance with University procedures and, for third parties, may constitute a breach of contract. Incidents involving personal data may be reportable to the Information Commissioner's Office under the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.

8. Related Policies, Standards and Regulations

- Information Security Policy
- Information Security Risk Management Policy
- Information Asset Owners Handbook
- Remote Working Policy
- ISO/IEC 27001:2013 — Annex A.8.1.3, A.8.2.1, A.8.2.2, A.8.2.3, A.8.3.2
- ISO/IEC 27002:2013 (implementation guidance)
- UK General Data Protection Regulation (UK GDPR) and Data Protection Act 2018

9. Policy Review

This policy will be reviewed at least annually, or sooner in response to significant organisational, legal, regulatory, or technological change. The Chief Information Security Officer is responsible for initiating the review.

10. Document Version History

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Change
1.0	01 June 2026	Chief Information Security Officer	Initial issue. Establishes the University information classification scheme.